

EVERY FALL IS FUEL

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Two and a half years ago, Jamahal Hill made UFC history.

He became the first graduate of Dana White's Contender Series (DWCS) to win a championship, claiming a unanimous decision victory over veteran Glover Teixeira. Hill, who debuted in the UFC in 2020, quickly built a reputation as a knockout artist. Before earning his maiden title shot, he delivered four first-round knockouts in five fights, showcasing his raw power and ruthless finishing ability.

"The first time I won the title; it was like a dream come true. To be a part of the UFC in itself was a dream, but to go in and get the job done is a different feeling. It was the result of years of hard work I put in," Hill tells *Sportstar*.

"The Dana White Contender Series is a good initiative. You get picked up if you're a top prospect based on your recent form. If you show up and perform, you get a platform to showcase what you're capable of," he adds.

But his reign was short-lived.

After two straight knockout losses, Jamahal Hill is back. The former champ eyes **redemption** with a statement win over Khalil Rountree Jr.

In his first title defence, Hill faced Alex Pereira and suffered a brutal first-round knockout. Pereira needed just one perfectly-timed left hook to end the bout and strip Hill of the belt.

Things didn't improve. A knee injury forced Hill to pull out of UFC 303, and on his return earlier this year, he was knocked out again — this time by Jiri Prochazka.

Still, Hill remains unfazed.

"Everything is part and parcel of the game. You win some, you lose some. If a fight doesn't go my way, I keep my head down and train to get better. I know what I'm capable of achieving. You just have to learn from your mistakes and grow," said Hill.

Now, he has a clear target in mind: redemption.

A dominant win over Khalil Rountree Jr. on June 22 could put him right back in the title mix. That's all he's focused on. "Right now, my only assignment is to go there and defeat Rountree. I want to go and express myself, and I believe everything else will follow accordingly. I feel I've had a pretty good build-up to the fight, and I want to dominate," concluded Hill.

Sony is the official broadcaster of UFC in India.

Power puncher: Jamahal Hill, who debuted in the UFC in 2020, quickly built a reputation as a knockout artist with his explosive finishes. GETTY IMAGES

